the hostile attitude of the local Europeans, he expressed unhappiness at how some Indians were behaving.[72]

The political environment of Tuticorin is best captured in an official report. Towards the end of 1906, when collectors of various districts of the Madras Presidency were asked to report on the progress of the Swadeshi movement, the overall assessment was that no appreciable impact could be felt: 'agitation against the use of foreign sugar, salt and saffron has not taken hold'; there was 'no widespread interest' in the matter of the boycott of foreign piece-goods. The final summary was that 'it may be taken for granted that the prospect of the movement and of the probable political results as being likely to produce any appreciable hostility to British rule … so far as this Presidency is concerned is *nil*'. To this italicized nil, the last line struck a contradictory note: 'The only district from which any suspicion of anti-British feeling is reported is Tinnevelly and there only in the town of Tuticorin.'[73] Tuticorin was becoming exceptional, but officials were still not ready to notice the brewing storm.

The local administration continued to hold this view until even mid-1907. On 25 May 1907 there was a protest meeting in Tuticorin against the transportation of the Punjab leaders Lajpat Rai and Ajit Singh. Joseph Louis Motha chaired the meeting while K.R. Venkatarama Aiyar and P.L. Vengu Aiyar spoke, apart from P.G. Venkataramanujalu Nayudu, described as secretary to SSNCo. While Motha was the man who handled the business with Shah Line Company, the other two were Tuticorin lawyers who played significant roles in the Swadeshi shipping company. The district administration remained unperturbed. Remarking on this meeting, the collector F.A. Coleridge said, 'I do not think there is the slightest chance of any trouble in Tuticorin. Except a few vakils the rest of the better-to-do people are much too intent on trade to care about politics.'[74] Writing in the same context, a week later, Coleridge wrote that he had no 'information to indicate that there is any feeling at all on the matter outside the vakil class and any pronounced feeling amongst the latter is hardly apparent outside Tuticorin and Palamcottah. No meeting of any importance was held on the subject except in Tuticorin …' The district collector continued,